I got back to my senses at about 7 p.m., when the effect of the anaesthesia wore off. I enquired about the encounter and was told that it was still continuing, that there had been no further casualties on our side, while about twenty terrorists had been shot dead. My younger brother, Lieutenant Colonel B.J. Singh, who was a medical specialist in the army, on learning of the incident, told me, 'Brother, it was a very close call for you. A few millimetres on either side and it could have been fatal – the femoral artery and vein pass through that region. It is divine intervention that has saved you!' 27 November 1991 was a long day and I can never forget Lieutenant Colonel Nagpal, the surgeon who saved my life.

A lot of visitors, including Corps Commander Lieutenant General Surinder Nath and Lieutenant General M.A. Zaki (Retd), the security adviser to the government of J&K, came to the hospital to wish me a speedy recovery. Captain S.S. Anjaria was decorated with a Sena Medal, and a few of his soldiers were also honoured for their gallant actions in this operation.

At some level, questions were raised as to why I had gone so far ahead. It was as if I had done something wrong! It was my considered view that I must always try and be upfront, share the same risks that my soldiers were facing, and damn well get to know what's going on. Irregular warfighting is often so messy and complicated that decisions of far-reaching consequences have to be taken there and then, in real time. For example, if women congregate and attempt to storm and effect the release of a detained terrorist leader, and further, if terrorists wearing burqas and masquerading as women are amongst them, and they open fire at our troops, what would you do? One faux pas is enough to ignite a storm. Those of us who have handled such situations and survived are the unsung heroes of this dirty war in J&K and the northeast and elsewhere in the world, be it Afghanistan, Iraq or Bosnia. As a leader I would like to be in the picture and importantly, in the front, rather than in my office. I am convinced that all commanders up to the rank of brigadier should consider themselves as field commanders and act accordingly. Beyond that rank, the general officers should decide for themselves as to when and where their